
AI'm by VNS

Why your website is invisible to AI search engines
and what you need to change it

*A practical guide for small businesses and sole traders
without a marketing team — Part 1 of 3*

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The problem nobody told you about

You have a website. Maybe you had it built years ago, maybe you updated it recently. You are on Google Maps, you have a Facebook page, perhaps even an Instagram profile. Yet when a potential customer asks an AI search engine where to find your service in their area, your name does not appear.

It is not your fault. Nobody told you, because until recently the problem did not exist.

AI search engines are changing the way people look for products and services. And the rules are completely different from traditional SEO.

AI search engines do not read your Facebook page, your Instagram profile, your Airbnb listing or your Booking.com profile. They read your website, but only if it is structured in the right way.

1. How AI search engines work

Google shows you a list of links. AI search engines give you a direct answer. That answer is built by reading specific web content; not all of it, only structured and publicly accessible content.

This means that if your website does not have the right technical structure, AI search engines simply do not know you exist, even if you are the best tradesperson in your area.

What AI search engines read:

- Your website, but only content structured in the HTML
- Schema.org data that describes who you are and what you do
- Special files like llms.txt that give instructions to AI crawlers
- Your blog, if it exists and is written in the right way

What they do NOT read:

- Your Facebook page or Instagram posts
- Your profile on Airbnb, Booking.com or TripAdvisor
- Your Google Business profile (Google Maps)
- WhatsApp messages or reviews on category portals

This is the most important point in this guide: all the work you have done on social media and portals counts for nothing with AI search engines. Only your website matters.

2. Why your website is probably not being read

Most websites are built to look good to people, not to be read by AI crawlers. This is not a flaw in your website; it is simply that AI technologies arrived later.

The three most common reasons:

1

Missing schema.org markup

Schema.org is a language that lets AI search engines understand who you are, what you do, where you are and how to contact you. Without it your website is anonymous text, like a business card with no name.

2

Missing technical files for AI crawlers

AI search engines use crawlers to read websites. If your site does not have the right files (llms.txt, updated robots.txt, sitemap.xml) these crawlers do not know how to behave and often read nothing at all.

3

Content not readable without JavaScript

Many modern websites load their content via JavaScript. AI crawlers often do not run JavaScript; they see a blank page. Key content must be visible directly in the HTML.

3. What you need to be found by AI search engines

The good news is that the problem is solvable. You do not need to rebuild your website from scratch; in most cases it is enough to add the right elements to what you already have.

The 5 essential elements:

1. Complete schema.org markup	The markup that describes your business: name, address, services, opening hours, contact details, areas served. It goes directly into the HTML of your website.
2. llms.txt file	A text file that gives AI crawlers instructions on how to read your site and what they can use. Simple but essential.
3. Updated robots.txt	The file that manages crawler access to your site. It must explicitly include modern AI crawlers such as GPTBot and PerplexityBot.
4. Sitemap.xml	The map of your website that helps crawlers find all your pages. It must always be kept up to date.
5. Static HTML content	Key information about your business (who you are, what you do, where you are) must be visible in plain HTML, not only after JavaScript has loaded.

These 5 elements are the foundation. In Part 2 of this series we will look in detail at how to implement them and how to check whether your website already has them.

4. A real example

Casa Cavour is a small B&B in Bertinoro, in the Romagna region of Italy. Before AI optimisation the website was well built for traditional SEO, but completely invisible to AI search engines: GEO score 0 out of 10.

After implementing the 5 essential elements described in this guide, plus an optimised GEO blog and complete schema.org markup, the website began appearing in AI search engine responses for local searches in the area.

Measurable results arrived within 4 to 8 weeks of completing the full optimisation. Not magic. Just structure.

0/10	4+/10	4-8
Initial GEO score	GEO score after optimisation	Weeks to first results

5. Your next steps

Now you know why AI search engines probably cannot find your business. The next step is to understand exactly what is missing from your specific website.

1. Follow @aimbyvns on Instagram to receive Part 2 of this series: the complete technical checklist with all the files to verify.
2. If you want to know right away what your website is missing, book a free 30-minute consultation: we will analyse your situation together, with no commitment.
3. Visit aim-vns.com/resources to download all free content as soon as it is published.

Book your free consultation

30 minutes to analyse your website's AI visibility. No commitment. Just concrete answers.

Book your free consultation

This guide is part of a series of 3 free resources by AI'm by VNS. Part 2 (technical checklist) and Part 3 (real case study with data) are available at aim-vns.com/resources as soon as they are published. Follow @aimbyvns on Instagram to stay updated.

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